musk-deer and rumours flew ‘that there were men in that country who had wings and feathers and could fly’. The Portuguese viceroy of Ormuz brought two ostriches, who ‘treated pieces of stone as if they were fruits’.

It was at this time that Akbar created a new genealogical seal, whose popularity would spread far beyond the Mughal Empire and would later be copied in the seal of the sultans of Sumatra. This seal was, according to scholar Annabel Teh Gallop, ‘a masterpiece of imperial symbolism’. A potent symbol of Mughal power and legitimacy, this ‘orbital’ seal had the name of the reigning emperor in the middle, surrounded by smaller circles containing the names of his ancestors up to Timur. The seal was engraved by the master engraver, Maulana Ali Ahmad ‘Nishani’, who was a friend of Badauni’s. His engraving skills were the least of his talents, according to Badauni, who praised his learning in ‘astronomy and natural history’. So saintly and exceptional was Nishani considered to be that his dies were carried as talismans by courtiers travelling abroad, to Khurasan and Transoxiana.

Even as the ostriches and yaks roamed in uneasy proximity with cheetahs and elephants, Akbar was busy arranging two weddings which were indirectly a rebuke and a punishment for Salim. Akbar and his eldest son had been involved in an unspoken imperial tussle over the allegiance of key mansabdars and allies of the court. As we have seen earlier, Salim had been actively courting the support of men considered louche and unreliable by Akbar. Angered by Salim’s jostling for power by nurturing these dangerous and unworthy friendships, Akbar now retaliated by removing two significant voices of support for Salim from within the royal harem. Salim’s sisters, Shakr un-Nisa Begum and Khanum Sultan Begum, were devoted to their brother and the coterie of women from within the harem thus exercised a considerable influence in favour of Salim. Now Akbar married them to Timurid cousins—men with pretensions to independent power themselves. These ambitious men would never tolerate being vassals to the prince’s cause and in this way Salim lost the powerful support of his two sisters.

Akbar added another grain of worry for Salim when he openly began to favour the prince’s own sons over their father. When Khusrau was seven years old, and had just begun learning ‘Indian philosophy’ under one Shiv Dutt Brahman, he was appointed to a rank of 5,000, equal with high-ranking amirs of the empire such as Raja Man Singh and Mirza Aziz Koka.